

Our topic today can be introduced by a question raised by Marilyn Adams:

“Suppose for the sake of argument that horrendous evil could be included in maximally perfect world orders. ...

Would the fact that God permitted horrors because they were means to His end of global perfection make the participant's life more tolerable, more worth living for him/her?”

Many have thought not. A perfectly good being would not create beings whose lives were not worth living for them, just to add to the total greatness of creation.

A reasonable argument can be made that there are. Some children are born with conditions which make their lives very short and painful. Other people suffer such terrible evils that they question whether their lives were worth living.

The implicit assumption that Adams is making is that a good God would
make every human life worth living.

Suppose that there were some human being whose life was not worth living for him or her. Would a perfectly good being be justified in creating such a being, even if there were outweighing goods for others which could not be realized without his or her existence?

Are there people whose lives are not worth living for them?

It is natural at this point for the believer in God to appeal to the existence of life after death. If there were no such thing as life after death, how could lives of this kind have been worth living?

In this way, consideration of the argument from evil leads naturally into questions about the possibility of life after death.

What do the major monotheistic religions tell us about life after death?

Within Judaism, positions on this question vary. But most Christian and Islamic denominations agree on the broad outlines of an answer. Here is the version of that answer given in the *Catechism of the Catholic Church*:

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, "of both the just and the unjust," will precede the Last Judgment. ... Christ will come "in his glory, and all the angels with him Before him will be gathered all the nations, and he will separate them one from another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand, but the goats at the left.... and they will go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life."

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will go to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the talk of the **last** judgement wouldn't make much sense.)

Our lead-in showed why it is plausible that responses to the argument from evil must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of view of life after death we get here compatible with God being perfectly good?



the
paradox of
heaven and
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replies to the
paradox



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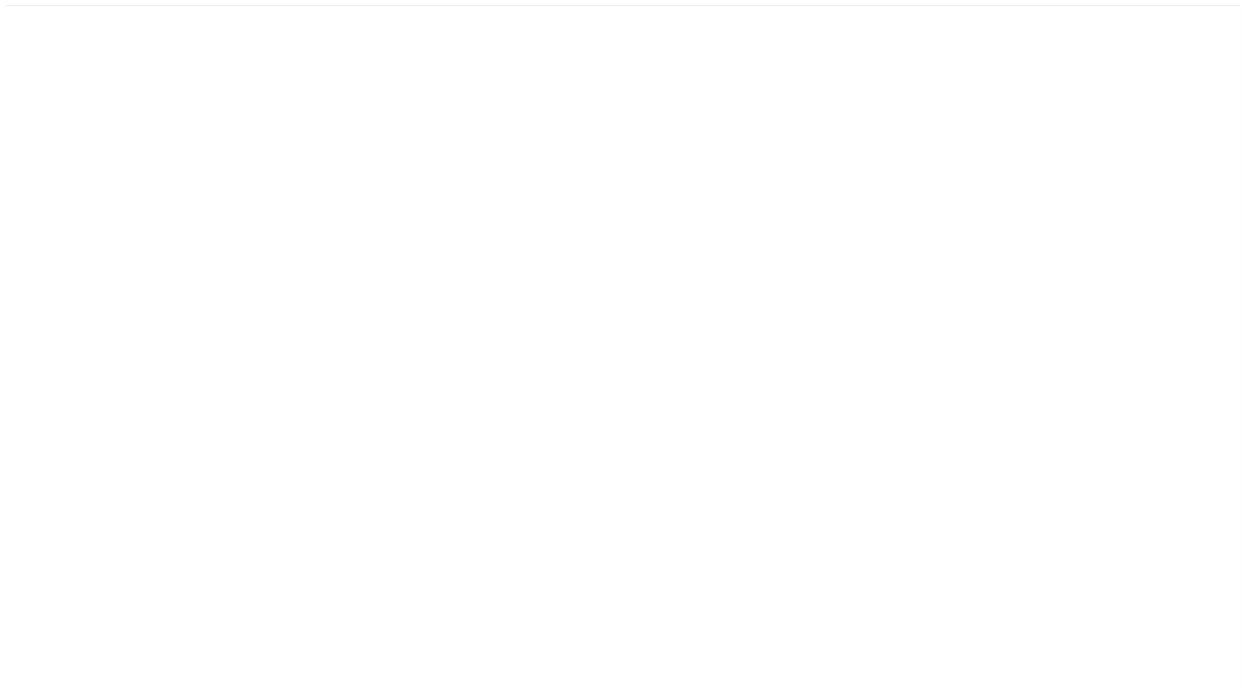
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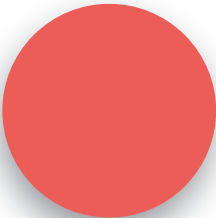
Our first question today is: what we are told about life after death by

perfectly good Good?



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Let's try to layout Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the

traditional doctrine of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with

the existence of a perfectly good God.

“A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is *binary*. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree. The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.”

heaven and hell based on certain properties of these people. We will have

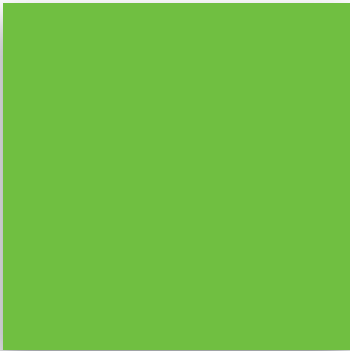
Let's call them the relevant properties.

It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to

open for what those properties might be; just have a name for them,



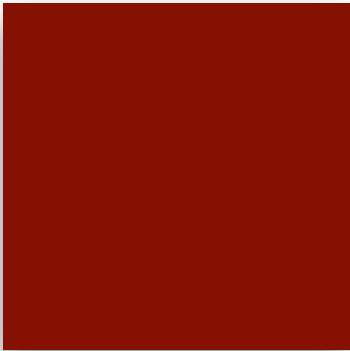












seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.

It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that





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